

Scratch

Scratch is the first programming language learned by many children. A visual language, it doesn't require users to type code. Instead, programs are made using coloured blocks that represent commands.

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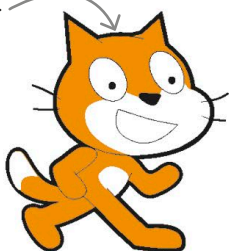
Background

Scratch was created by the Lifelong Kindergarten group at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) in the USA. They wanted to make it easier for children aged 8–16 to learn how to code. It emphasizes the creative potential of code, allowing children to create interactive stories, games, art, and more.

Scratch cat is Scratch's mascot and the default character in projects.

▷ Scratch worldwide

Designed to be fun as well as educational, Scratch has a worldwide community of users who share their creations with each other.



TOP TECH

ScratchJr

This is a simplified version of Scratch for 5–7 year olds. It allows users to make animations and interactive stories by clicking together coloured blocks representing commands. Blocks mainly feature symbols rather than text and there are fewer than in the standard version. It's available as an app for tablets, rather than a desktop program.



How does it work?

To "write" a program in Scratch, the user drags together coloured blocks that represent instructions. The instructions control images and sounds on the area of the window called the "stage". Scratch doesn't require users to have previous programming skills. The main abilities needed are basic reading, numeracy, and sufficient skill with a computer mouse to drag blocks to the desired locations.

▽ Scratch 2.0 screen

A program in Scratch is called a project, and its window is split into several areas, each with its own features.

Stage

The stage area is where sprites perform the actions that the code tells them to. Clicking the blue rectangle icon in the top-left corner makes this window full screen.

Sprites

Scratch programs control objects called sprites. Sprites can move around the stage area and interact with each other. Alternating between a sprite's "costumes" creates a simple cartoon animation effect.

